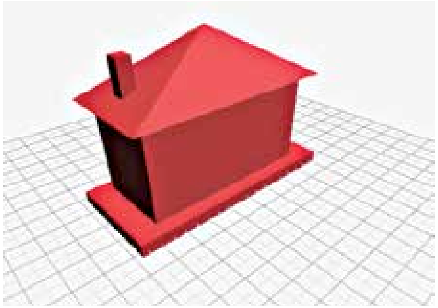
SimCity offline mode coming

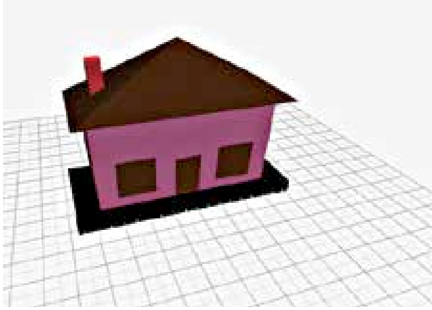
After staunchly denying the feature at launch, EA has finally caved to player demand and community outcry, and they'll soon release an offline mode for SimCity **http://dgit.in/simoffline**

Meet SteamVR

Valve has announced an Oculus Rift mode of Steam called SteamVR. A match made in heaven? **http://dgit.in/SteamVR**



The basic shape of a house



Home! Sweet Home!

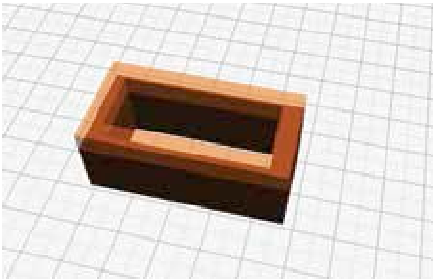
available to all the other shapes are not present for cubes and objects composed of cubes. With that advisory out of the way, let's get on to drawing an actual 3D model.

Let's start building a house. A simple, ground plus one affair with pink walls, a large sloping roof, chimney and a nice solid foundation.

1) Lay the foundation with the 'Add Geometries' tool and search for rectangle in the search field. Select the sheared box and key-in the values for its length (X), height (Y) and width (Z) and hit 'Add'. Find a suitable spot on your workspace to place the foundation. You can make the foundation bigger by placing more rectangles next to each other and clicking 'View Rotate' to get rid of the shape.
2) The next step is adding the walls. Use the same method, but this time, remember to make the height (Y) greater than the width (Z) and place all the four walls.
3) Next, for the roof draw a tetrahedron (better known as a pyramid) and place it over the walls. Click 'View Rotate' and then the tetrahedron to bring up the 'Object' toolbar and select 'scale'. Extend the shape across the X, Y and Z axes and centre it.
4) The chimney is just one cuboid on the roof with one end buried into the roof. Our house is almost ready!
5) Throw in the appropriate colors using the color change tool. All that's left now is the detailing.
6) Using the basic shapes available, with a thickness of 0.1, create a door and square-shaped windows for the lower floors. Group squares with half cylinders to make windows for the upper floors and the house is complete!

It would be pertinent to point out at this point that the entire house could in fact be constructed entirely with cubes using the 'Add Cube' tool which brings us to a tool available only to cubes in the object toolbar. The tool is called 'Extrude' and basically adds layer upon layer of an already present object, effectively building walls and other raised objects without going through the trouble of keying in exact values.

Let's try making the walls of the same house only with cubes. Click the 'Add Cube' button and place your cubes next to each other to form a rectangle. Once you hit the 'View Rotate' button and click on the newly drawn shape, an object toolbar will appear with a few missing tools



Horizontal extrusion using the Extrude tool

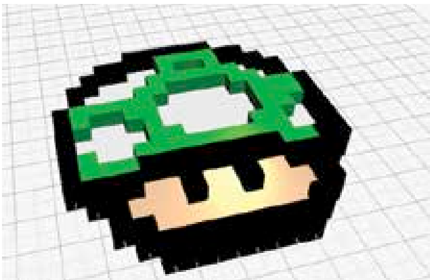
and a few extras. The extras of course include the extrude tool, with which – as we mentioned before – you can add layer upon layer of an object onto it. As long as it's on a flat surface, you can extend an object till infinity in one direction with the extrude tool.

The other extra tools include 'Inflate', which allows you to double the object's dimensions symmetrically and 'Edit', which takes you to the 'Smoothen' tool. This smoothens out the edges of an object.

A word of advice

All said and done, this nifty little application has its own drawbacks. While some of the controls are very intuitive to engage, disengaging them takes some getting used to. Take, for example, the 'View Rotate' tool. Once you click it, you're at liberty to move the camera around at any angle. While one would instinctively hold the left button and move the cursor, it isn't necessary and you're left a little annoyed when you realize that you need to click the left button again unless you enjoy playing a violent game of earthquake with your design.

Another thing to keep in mind is in terms of moving the objects around. You must remember that any object from a particular camera view can be moved only along two axes at a time. That is, if you're facing the house head on, the door once created, can be moved up and down or left and right but not back and forth. Although in this particular example moving an object through a third dimension on a 2-dimensional display is sort of impossible, the same gets a little cumbersome when the camera angle is a little off to the side and you think you've got the angle right.



8-bit 1-Up by Robb

On the whole, 3DTin is simply brilliant if you want to draw a mock-up or rough 3D rendering for presentations and prototypes. Even more impressive is the fact that the cube-based rendering option makes generating stuff like the 1-Up mushroom from Mario by user Robb shown here, a cinch. And since 3DTin is affiliated to Creative Commons, if allowed by the creator, you can actually fire up your 3D printer and print some amazing work made by some amazing people! Just don't sell the models.